

PHONE INTAKE & DISPATCH GUIDE

For office staff and anyone answering the main line. Revision 9 — February 2026. Keep this at the desk.

The single most important rule: we would rather take four extra minutes on the phone than roll a truck to the wrong job. Get the address, the problem, and whether water is actively running. Everything else can be sorted out later.

1. Answering the Call

Answer within three rings. Standard greeting:

“Thank you for calling Savior Plumbing, this is _____. How can I help you today?”

If the caller opens in Spanish, switch or transfer. We are a bilingual shop and this is a point of pride — never make a Spanish-speaking caller struggle through English.

Set the frame early

- Get the caller's name in the first 30 seconds and use it through the call.
- Let them describe the problem once, uninterrupted, before you start asking questions.
- Confirm you understand by playing it back: “So the water heater is leaking from the bottom and there's water on the garage floor — is that right?”
- Never dead-air. If you're typing, say you're typing.

2. Required Intake Fields

Every call, without exception. A job cannot be dispatched without the first six.

#	Field	Notes / how to ask
1	Caller name	First and last. Spell the last name back.
2	Best callback number	Confirm whether it accepts text — techs text their ETA.
3	Service address	Full street address plus city. Gate or unit number if applicable.
4	Property type	House, condo, apartment, or commercial. Changes who we send.
5	Owner or tenant	If tenant, we need landlord or property manager authorization before work.
6	Problem description	In the customer's own words first, then your triage questions.
7	How long has it been happening	Distinguishes emergency from routine.
8	Is water actively running or leaking now	This is the emergency trigger. Ask it on every water call.
9	Have they shut off the water	If not, walk them through it — see section 4.

#	Field	Notes / how to ask
10	Has anyone else worked on it	Recent work by others changes our approach and our warranty.
11	Access constraints	Dogs, gate codes, stairs, parking, hours the building allows work.
12	Preferred appointment window	Offer what dispatch actually has. Do not invent availability.
13	How they heard about us	Google, Yelp, referral, repeat customer, drove by.

3. Triage Matrix

Use this to decide urgency. When in doubt, treat it as more urgent, not less.

Caller says	Priority	What to do
Water actively flooding, cannot stop it	EMERGENCY	Walk them to the main shutoff immediately (section 4). Then get dispatch on it. Interrupt Danny if needed.
Sewage backing up into the home	EMERGENCY	Health hazard. Tell them to stop using all water fixtures. Same-day if at all possible.
Smell of gas	EMERGENCY	Stop. Tell them to leave the building and call PG&E at 1-800-743-5000 first. We come after the utility clears it.
No water at all in the house	Urgent	Same-day if we have capacity. Ask if neighbors also lost water — may be a utility issue, not us.
No hot water	Urgent	Same-day if possible. Get the water heater's age, fuel type, and location before dispatch.
Water heater leaking	Urgent	Ask if it's dripping or pouring. Pouring from the tank body means replacement, not repair.
Only toilet in the home is clogged	Urgent	Treat as urgent. If they have a second working bathroom, it drops to same-week.
Slow drain, one fixture	Routine	Next available. Usually 1–3 business days.
Dripping faucet, running toilet	Routine	Next available. Bundle with other small items if they have any.
Wants a quote for a remodel or repipe	Estimate visit	Book a site visit. Written quote follows by next business day.
Commercial property, any issue	Route to Danny	Do not quote. Take full details and have Danny call back.

4. Talking a Caller Through the Main Shutoff

You are not giving plumbing advice. You are stopping property damage while we drive there. Stay calm and keep your voice slow.

“Okay, I want to get the water stopped first and then we'll talk about getting someone out. Are you able to walk outside for me?”

- **Most homes here:** the shutoff is in a concrete box at the street near the sidewalk, or on an exterior wall near the front hose bibb.
- **Turn direction:** clockwise, or turn the lever so it sits crosswise to the pipe.

- **Water heater only:** there is usually a separate valve on the cold inlet on top of the heater.
- **If they can't find it or can't turn it:** stop. Don't have them force anything. Escalate to same-day dispatch and stay on the line if they're panicking.

Never instruct a caller to open a gas line, relight a pilot on a unit that smells of gas, or use a drain chemical. If a caller has already poured chemical drain cleaner down the line, note it on the work order — the tech needs to know before they open anything.

5. Scheduling Rules

Topic	Rule
Business hours	Monday–Friday, 7:30am to 4:30pm. Office closed Saturday and Sunday.
Weekends / after hours	By appointment only. Do not book directly — take the details and tell them the office will confirm.
Appointment windows	Two-hour windows. Morning 8–10, 10–12. Afternoon 12–2, 2–4.
Same-day	Often available but never guaranteed. Say “often we can” — never “we will.”
ETA calls	The tech calls or texts 20–30 minutes out. Tell the customer to expect this.
Running late	If a tech will miss the window, the office calls the customer before the window closes. Not after.
Cancellations	No fee if cancelled before the tech is dispatched.
Rescheduling	Free. Just move it. Don't make the customer feel bad about it.
Service area	Alameda and Contra Costa counties. If they're outside, say so honestly and offer a referral if you know one.

6. What You Can and Cannot Say About Price

You CAN say	You CANNOT say
The diagnostic fee is \$89 during business hours, and it's waived if they approve the repair that same visit.	A firm price for any repair before a tech has seen it.
Estimates are free for most services.	An after-hours or weekend price. That rate is not finalized — take a message.
Larger or complex projects get a written quote by the next business day.	Any commercial price. Route to Danny.
All our pricing is flat rate, so they'll know the full price before any work starts.	An hourly rate. We do not sell hours.
We honor a 2-year labor warranty on our work.	That a specific past job is covered — check the history first.
A general range, clearly labeled as a range, for very common jobs (see the price book).	A range for anything you had to look up twice. If you're unsure, don't.

“I don't want to guess and be wrong — that's not how we do it. What I can tell you is the diagnostic is \$89, and if you go ahead with the repair we take that off. The technician gives you the full flat-rate price before he touches anything.”

7. Common Questions and Approved Answers

Question	Answer
Are you licensed and insured?	Yes. Licensed, bonded, and insured. Our techs are trained journeyman plumbers.
How long have you been around?	Since 2000. Family-owned and locally operated.
Do you have a warranty?	Two-year labor warranty on our work.
Are you Diamond Certified?	Yes — 14 consecutive years, and voted best in Pleasanton.
Do you speak Spanish?	Yes, our team is bilingual.
Do you do commercial?	Yes. Take details and route to Danny for the quote.
Can I pay online?	Yes, there's a Pay Online page on our website.
What payment methods?	NOT DOCUMENTED — confirm with Marisol before answering.
Do you offer financing?	NOT DOCUMENTED — do not promise. Take a message.
Do you work with home warranty companies?	NOT DOCUMENTED — escalate to the office.
Do you bill insurance for water damage?	NOT DOCUMENTED — escalate.
Is there a senior or military discount?	NOT DOCUMENTED — escalate.
Can you give me a price over the phone?	Explain flat-rate and the diagnostic. See section 6.

8. Escalation & Transfers

Route to	For
Dispatch — ext. 101	Scheduling, changes, ETA questions, adding a job to the board.
Danny O. — ext. 103	Commercial anything, pricing questions, scope disputes, tech escalations.
Marisol R. — ext. 102	Billing, invoices, warranty verification, complaints, payment questions.
Owner	Only if Marisol and Danny are both unavailable and the caller is escalating.

Handling an upset caller

- Let them finish. Do not defend, explain, or interrupt.
- Acknowledge the specific thing that went wrong, not a generic apology.
- Never blame the technician, the schedule, or another company while on the phone.
- Commit to one concrete next step with a time attached: “Marisol will call you back before 4 o'clock today.”
- Then actually make sure that happens. A missed callback is how a two-star review gets written.

9. Taking a Message

If nobody can take the call, the message must contain all of the following or it's not useful:

- Name, callback number, and whether the number takes texts.
- Service address.
- One-line problem summary in the caller's words.

- Urgency per the triage matrix.
- What you told them — especially any timeframe you promised.
- Who it needs to go to and by when.

Open items for this revision — Marisol to confirm: after-hours rate structure • accepted payment methods • financing options • home warranty and insurance policy • discount programs • whether we service Tracy and Livermore edge addresses • holiday closure list.

SAMPLE / FICTIONAL DOCUMENT — created for software testing. Staff names, extensions, prices, and policies are invented and do not reflect actual Savior Plumbing personnel or practices.